

Most cameras came with an inbuilt memory of 16 MB. SD and MMC were the formats of choice. Canon's cameras came with 32 MB Compact Flash cards and no inbuilt memory. The same was the case with the Sony P73, which had a 16MB MemoryStick. The Casio was at the bottom of the list. It had less than 10 MB of inbuilt memory. It can hold no more than a paltry five images at high resolutions.

Such cameras are handicapped in a way. You are compelled to buy additional memory modules if you plan to take loads of photos. Moreover, copying a photo to an external memory



The Casio Exilim Ex-Z30

card is a slower process than storing it internally. The user has to keep this in mind while taking fast shots, such as scenes from a sporting event.

It is also advisable to carry a

good number of medium-capacity cards than just one or two high-capacity cards. The reason is again speed of access. A large card will take much longer to refresh with a new photo than a smaller one.

Another key issue—battery life. Does your camera support rechargeable batteries? Does it come with a charger? If yes, then note that these are some features worth spending on.

The Canon A75 was the only camera powered by four AA batteries. Both the Nikon models and the Sony P73 came with two AA rechargeable Ni-MH batteries.

The Casio, the Orite VC-R500 and the VC-5000Z had proprietary Li-Ion batteries, the proprietary nature of which turned out to be both good and bad. Good because the running cost is significantly lower as one doesn't have to worry about battery replacement, and bad because the camera can't be used outdoors over long periods of time. Once the batteries get drained, you don't even have the option of replacing them with regular ones.

PictBridge is a standard that enables a digital camera to connect directly to a PictBridge-compliant printer to print images. Interestingly, this feature completely bypasses the PC. Canon, Casio, Nikon, Sony,

Limited memory in cameras belonging to this price range (sub-Rs 30,000) is really sad, because if the camera is used to capture images at the best possible resolution the supplied memory will not last more than 10 frames

Mukesh Parpiani
Photo Editor,
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Olympus and Samsung 307 were all PictBridge ready.

Three models from Kodak and lesser-known brands such as D'zign, Premier and Orite didn't support the standard. However, the Kodak cameras came with connectors at the bottom, which let them connect to a Kodak printer dock. You need a Dye-Sublimation printer for this to get the printouts directly.

Were They Easy To Use?

The Nikon Coolpix 3200 and 4100 sported an identical design with the same layout of buttons, as well. The cameras are very comfortable to hold, and navigating their interface is simple, with self-explanatory settings.

The Casio Ex-Z30 is slim and



The slim Casio EX-Z30 has the biggest LCD screen in its category

light, but the buttons are tiny. The camera, however, has a very impressive navigation, especially when it comes to different modes. This, coupled with a large and impressive LCD, makes it an attractive option.

Three models from Kodak and two from Olympus were quite large. However, the menu navigation on the Kodak was the simplest of them all. The icons are big, and the tags are explanatory.

The Canon A75 was the bulkiest of the lot, and its weight shoots up once the four AA batteries are plugged in. The camera, however, sports a very sturdy design and feels comfortable to hold.

The button placement, especially the zoom button, is very



Nikon's Coolpix 4100 reproduced good colour tones

Our Expert Panel

Digit consulted two of India's top professional news photographers before deciding the winners



Palashranjan Bhaumik
Photo Editor,
Business India

In the world of news photography, Palashranjan Bhaumik is a pint-sized giant. He is 48, but looks 10 years younger thanks to the energy he brings to his work and life. He is photo editor of Business India, one of India's most respected business magazines, a post he has held for several years now. He has been shooting pictures since he was 14, and everything that he has learned is self-taught. His first camera was the Kodak 620 box camera.

He swears by digital photography, but also feels that the old world charm and the quality offered by manual cameras will never die. He says: "Digital photography is the order of the day. It has captured the minds of millions, and is growing tremendously. In a fast moving world like ours, digital photography is the only way to match with its ever growing demand."



Mukesh Parpiani
Photo Editor,
Mid Day

Mukesh Parpiani is photo editor of Mid Day, Mumbai's second largest selling newspaper. The multi-award winning news photographer has been on the forefront of news journalism for over two decades, and has worked with some of India's premier publications, including The Indian Express. Some of his photographs depicting human life in India were used in the award-winning ad campaign of Indya.com in the year 2000.

He says: "For today's news professional, digital photography is a must. Even though some people still prefer the old way of functioning, digital cameras give you all the flexibility you need. Even amateurs find it easier to shoot on digital. With technology making rapid progress, there is little difference in quality between a digital photo and a photo clicked on manual SLRs."